came to increasingly view the Taliban through a terrorism-centric lens. As for Iran and Russia, their aversion to the Taliban only rose as the latter captured Taloqan and Kunduz in North Afghanistan with Pakistan's help.[34] Barring Pakistan, the dominant advocacy within the six plus two grouping, thus, was Taliban-averse. Though Washington remained lukewarm in pressuring Pakistan, Russian PM Yevgeny Primakov assured continuous support to Jaswant Singh in July 1999 and categorically stated that 'the globe cannot live with a Talibanised Pakistan that has the bomb'.[35]

Despite, largely, being on the same page with the partisans in India, the six plus two process did not go down well in India. New Delhi's exclusion from the grouping at Pakistan's behest irritated New Delhi considerably.[36] Having lost faith in the UN's capability to resolve the conflict and seething over its marginalisation from international groupings, the MEA officially criticised the process saying that it was 'inherently flawed on account of its narrow and constricted base'.[37] India asserted that notwithstanding its lack of recognition of the Taliban, and its opposition to the manner in which the Taliban permitted itself to be manipulated by Pakistan, direct contact was established with the regime during the IC-814 hijacking. The Taliban's correct role as facilitators during this crisis was noted, but it was clear that the fundamentals of India's Afghanistan policy would not change. Though India welcomed the 1999 Tashkent declaration that vindicated its stand and supported the partisans, it remained critical of multilateral processes on Afghanistan in which it did not have a role. When the Congress-led opposition challenged the government's lack of persistence on joining the six plus two and meekly accepting Washington's exclusion of India,[38] Jaswant Singh dismissed the allegations saying, 'we did take a decision that we will have nothing to do with six plus two because the countries that were part of the six plus two were a part of the problem. How can problems [Pakistan] become solutions? And, I don't want to name the countries'.[39]

Jaswant Singh's reaction was problematic for various reasons. Firstly, regardless of India's absence, the six plus two proved somewhat effective in pressuring Pakistan to bring the Taliban to the negotiation table. It was, arguably, the only platform at that point in time that saw different Afghan factions talk with each other.[40] The Taliban representatives who attended the meetings came under